
Introduction

The direction in which the team explores solutions is not predetermined. The goal of transdisciplinary learning is to be innovative, and this carries the risk that the team may not make much progress toward a solution. If they choose to stay with the problem longer, this can also be highly valuable, as it allows for a deeper understanding of the issue from multiple perspectives. Often, solutions to certain problems are ineffective because the problem itself is misunderstood. Therefore, understanding the problem—or recognizing its complexity—can be a **crucial outcome**.

You can read more about these **invisible outcomes** on the theory page.

The practice page offers examples of such results.

Theory

Understanding Not-Knowing

One possible outcome is the realization that there is no shared solution to the specific problem, which can be disappointing. However, this can also offer the opportunity to take a step back, redefine the problem, and examine the system in which the problem arose. This may lead to further questions or reveal other issues that need to be addressed before tackling the chosen complex problem.

Understanding Multiple Perspectives

Another possible outcome is gaining insight into different perspectives on the same issue (Oonk et al.,

2022). This can be achieved by collaborating with people from different disciplines, sectors, and/or cultural backgrounds. In doing so, boundaries are crossed. It also provides an opportunity to reflect on your own perspective.

Questions like: *How do I view the problem?* This helps define your own position and understand the complexity of multiple viewpoints. You are now aware that the outcome of a transdisciplinary collaboration is not just the innovative idea or “product” the team comes up with. To avoid disappointment among students, educators, or stakeholders, expectations must be carefully managed from the start.

Reference:

Oonk, C., Gulikers, J., den Brok, P., & Mulder, M. (2022). *Stimulating boundary crossing learning in a multi-stakeholder learning environment for sustainable development*. *International Journal of Sustainability in Higher Education*, 23(8), 21–40.

Practice

This page is still under development. Examples will follow soon.

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